

sense of humour. But I'm not a comedian, frankly. Comedians always have to be on their toes. Comics need stage presence."

Stand-up comic Zakir Khan has been tracking Bam's career since 2016 and helps us break down his success: "What makes him beautiful is how grounded he is. As an artist, he also explores and expands himself a lot. He never gets fixated. He has an unfailing ability to learn. Being funny is secondary. For people to laugh with you, they have to like and love you. That, for me, is the magic of Bhuvan Bam." Besides likeability, Khan also believes that Bam's grit sets him apart. A few months before the release of *Dhindora*, Bam lost both his parents to India's second Covid wave. "Despite such great personal loss, the way he bounced back and delivered *Dhindora* is one reason why everybody was with him."

Bam, 27, says he couldn't stay in Delhi after his parents died. "I left for Mumbai the next day. I couldn't stay in the same house. I don't know how I balanced things, but it somehow happened. I am glad that *Dhindora* kept me so busy that I didn't have time to think about the extent of my loss."

Tanishk Bagchi, too, lost his father in 2020. "My father, Nandakumar Bagchi, used to work with R.D. Burman, Satyajit Ray and Salil Chaudhury. He played the guitar and my mother played the Hawaiian guitar. I think God had this plan made that I would come to Bombay because of my dad and mom's efforts. Whatever my parents couldn't achieve in their lives, I would then achieve for them," he says.

Growing up in Kolkata, Bagchi always knew that he had to get to Mumbai to start playing in the big leagues. In the first years, the only thing maximum about the city was the extent of Bagchi's efforts. It was with 'Banno' in *Tanu Weds Manu Returns* (2015) that Bagchi was first noticed, but it was finally with 'The Humma Song' in *OK Jaanu* (2017) that he was able to create a stir. A reimagination of A.R. Rahman's classic 'Humma Humma', Bagchi's version hit a note that even Rahman approved.

"That one song really worked, and after that it kind of became my purpose to bring songs I loved—like those of Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan Saab and Rahman Sir—to the new generation with a new sound," says Bagchi, 41. He wanted the songs of his heroes to be played again in clubs and new year parties. In the past few years, Bagchi's recreations—'Tamma Tamma', 'Mere Rashke Qamar', 'Masakali 2.0'—have been criticised for being inauthentic, even formulaic, but numbers and stats suggest a very different story.

Released this year, 'Lut Gaye', Bagchi's rendition of a 1983 Nusrat Fateh Ali Khan hit, was the fastest Hindi song to hit that one billion mark on YouTube. "These songs are like a journey for me. It's like I am trying to reach the legend and my songs somehow help me do that," says Bagchi. Given the sheer range of Bagchi's music—he says he has already made over 200 songs—you are likely to find one for every mood now. "Take 'Raataan Lambiyan', for instance. I knew it isn't a dance song but I also knew that it will create history. It is when soulful songs like this get liked that I start to feel that maybe I am a success."

It seems strange that in a year when other Bollywood composers have struggled to stay relevant, Bagchi has his diary and track roster full until 2023. Like Bam, there's a code he, too, has surely cracked. ■